HCP 1158 (cpc_1915--12_HU_Mezokovesd_HU_Szomolya_szomolya-44): a love poem in digits to Margitka Sziber

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Status: all 316 cipher signs are deciphered (314 by the key as written, 2 by word sense); independent review 1 verdict ACCEPT, five minor corrections made, no word of the reading changed. The open text is fully read. Report dated 2026-11-02.

Origin and context

The cryptogram is record 1158 of the HC Portal (https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1158), portal name cpc_1915--12_HU_Mezokovesd_HU_Szomolya_szomolya-44, from Tobias Schrödel's cryptographic postcards collection (private collection). When captured on 2026-11-02 the portal listed it as **Not solved**, category Substitution, language Unknown, sender Unknown, recipient Margitka Sziber, with no transcription or solution attached. The portal links a HistoCrypt article (https://ecp.ep.liu.se/index.php/histocrypt/article/view/166). That article was not checked for this card, so it is not known whether it discusses it.

The card went from Mezőkövesd to the village of Szomolya in north-east Hungary in wartime. A note in the margin, written sideways, gives the place and date: "Mezőkövesd: 1916, I/11." The address reads "Őnagysága / Rózsareményü / Sziber Margitka / kisasszonynak / (Borsod m.) Szomolya / u. p. Bogács", that is, "To Her Ladyship, the rose-promising young lady Margitka Sziber, Szomolya, Borsod county, post office Bogács". "Rózsareményü" looks like a play on the usual title "Szépreményű" (promising).

Unlike most cards of this correspondence, which hide only a few tender words in open Hungarian, this one is almost entirely in cipher. Only a five-line request at the top, the margin note and the address are in clear. The cipher part is a salutation, four rhymed stanzas and a closing signed Árpád, the same name as on other cards to Margitka. The picture side is a sepia studio photograph of a couple with a bunch of roses, and it has no writing.



Message and address side (source/address-large.jpg)



Picture side, no cipher text (source/picture-large.jpg)

Method

The transcription is manual, from the un-converted high-resolution scan enlarged line by line. No OCR was used. The card was read with a **known, transferred key**: the digit-plus-mark table reconstructed on the finished sister cards HCP 1174, 1178 and 1179 was applied, and the digits turned straight into Hungarian on the first pass. The sign shapes were still read one by one, and several first readings were corrected by looking again at the pixels, never by changing the key: `meshoz` became egymáshoz once the high dot was seen, sevezünk became beevezünk, `csókollak` became `csókol` hű, and a sign in line 13 proved to be the uncrossed `1.` = a.

Two signs not in the sister tables were added here from word sense: `4.` = gy, occurring 4 times in vagy, egymáshoz, hogyha and `légy`, and 6 = j, occurring once in `gondolj`. Both fit the family pattern, where a mark on a digit gives a second letter (g/gy on 4, n/j on 6), and neither collides with an established value.

In review the reviewer made its own contrast-enhanced crops, re-keyed all 316 signs and decoded them with its own script, which uses only the HCP 1174 table. Its token stream is identical to the solver's. It read the card with the solver's transcription in view, so this is a careful check and not a blind second reading.

Key

Monoalphabetic substitution on Hungarian. A digit and its mark form one sign, and the Hungarian digraphs cs, gy and sz have one sign each. The key does not mark vowel length, except that a/á and e/é have separate signs; o/ó, ö/ő, i/í and ü/ű share a sign.

Sign	Plain	Sign	Plain	Sign	Plain
`0`	o, ó	`2.`	é	`5,`	l
`0,`	ö, ő	`3`	d	`6`	j (new)
`1`	i, í	`3,`	r	`6,`	n
`1.`	a	`3.`	v	`7`	k
`1:`	e	`4,`	g	`7,`	s
`1'` (high dot)	á	`4.`	gy (new)	`7.`	sz
`:1` (dots to the left)	ü, ű	`5`	h	`8`	m
`1,`	b	`2,`	cs	`8,`	t
`9`	p	`9,`	z		

The card uses 26 distinct signs. Word gaps are mostly kept on the card, but not everywhere.

Plaintext

Clear note at the top, literally, with the card's line ends:

```
Ha lapomat megkapod és
válaszolni fogsz légyél szíves-
megirni a Pista címét
mert szeretnek már neki-
is irni.
```

Normalised: Ha lapomat megkapod és válaszolni fogsz légyél szíves megirni a Pista címét mert szeretnék már neki is irni.

Cipher part, with accents normalised where the key does not mark them. Each verse line is one written line of the card.

```
Édes Margitkám!

Terem virág kis kertemben,
```

```
Terem künn a réten,
De a legszebb virág te vagy
Édes mindenségem.

Ha egymáshoz kincsem
Igaz szívvel leszünk
A boldogság révébe
Meglásd beevezünk.

Írd meg nékem édes szentem
Drága virágszálom
Leszel-e hogyha megkérlek
A szerető párom.

Ezt a pár sort küldöm
Neked szép babám
Légy boldog és gondolj
Néha-néha rám.

Számtalanszor üdvözöl és csókol hű kedvesed Árpád
```

Margin: Mezőkövesd: 1916, I/11.

English translation

If you get my card and are going to answer, please be so kind as to write me Pista's address, because I would like to write to him too.

Sweet Margitka!

Flowers grow in my little garden, / they grow out on the meadow, / but the loveliest flower is you, / my sweet everything.

If to each other, my treasure, / we are true of heart, / into the harbour of happiness, / you'll see, we will row.

Write and tell me, my sweet saint, / my dear flower-stem, / will you, if I ask you, / be my loving partner.

These few lines I send / to you, my pretty darling; / be happy and think / of me now and then.

Countless times your faithful sweetheart Árpád greets and kisses you.

Slovak translation

Ak dostaneš môj lístok a budeš odpovedať, buď taká láskavá a napíš mi Pištovu adresu, lebo by som mu chcel tiež napísať.

Sladká Margitka!

Rastie kvet v mojej záhradke, / rastie vonku na lúke, / no najkrajší kvet si ty, / moje sladké všetko.

Ak k sebe, môj poklad, / budeme úprimného srdca, / do prístavu šťastia, / uvidíš, doveslujeme.

Napíš mi, moja sladká svätá, / drahý môj kvietok, / či budeš, ak ťa požiadam, / mojou milujúcou družkou.

Týchto pár riadkov ti posielam, / moja pekná milá; / buď šťastná a mysli / na mňa občas.

Nespočetnekrát ťa pozdravuje a bozkáva tvoj verný milý Árpád.

Why the reading is believed correct

- The key was fixed on other cards and was not fitted to this one, yet it gives 18 lines of connected Hungarian. Even with no repairs and no new signs the text already reads `terem virág kis kertemben` and `a boldogság révébe`.

- The text rhymes: réten/mindenségem, leszünk/beevezünk, virágszálom/párom, babám/rám. Rhyme is independent of the key.
- The name Árpád, the salutation Édes Margitkám and the closing words match HCP 1174.
- The address and the open note agree with the Mezőkövesd correspondence.

Uncertainties

Two signs that do not give the letter by the key:

- virágszálom: the first sign is a plain 3 (d) with no dot, while sense needs 3. (v). The literal form is dirágszálom. It is probably a dropped dot, since virág is written correctly twice.
- szentem: the last sign has a clear comma, so the key gives 8, = t (szentet), while the vocative needs m. It may be a slip or a line-end comma. The sense is not in doubt in either case.

Signs read by the key but partly dependent on word sense:

- kincsem: the first sign's lower part is under a blot, so any mark would be hidden. The crossed 7 shows, and k rests on the word.
- hű: the lower dot stands left of the 1 and the upper dot is not separate; the thick flag tip may hold it. Other readings give no word.
- meglásd: the upper dot of 1: coincides with the printed vertical text "Printed in Germany". 1. would give no word.
- ezt a: the a sign is uncrossed, so it is read as 1., not 7..
- üdvözöl: the 0 before 5, looks like a 9 because its comma touches it, so ö rests on sense.
- egymáshoz: the 8 carries a heavy extra stroke through its upper loop, like a correction. It still reads as 8 and the word is secure.
- 6 = j rests on one occurrence. The alternatives give no word.

Punctuation and open text:

- A heavy) follows kedvesed and another follows Árpád, with no opening bracket visible. The purpose is unknown. They and the ! of the salutation are not cipher signs.
- légyél seems to carry an accent on the first e; the normal form is legyél. The card has szeretnek with no accent, normalised to szeretnék by sense.
- The date rests on the writer's margin note. The catalogue name says 1915--12. The postmark shows Mezőkövesd in part, and when turned level its date strip shows a group ending in 6 and a day group beginning with 1. That would suit 916 and January, but it is not a secure reading.
- Pista is not identified. No search was made for a printed source of the verse, and a grep of the sister solutions found it on no other card.

Review

An independent reviewer (a separate Claude Opus 5.5 agent) tried to refute the reading and could not. It ran the solver's command, re-keyed and decoded all 316 signs, enlarged each disputed sign 4 to 6 times, and checked the open text, the translations and the rhyme. Verdict **ACCEPT**, with five minor findings, all addressed. None changed a word of the reading.

- The count of 4. was wrong (5); it is 4.
- The closing brackets and the salutation's ! were unrecorded; they are now noted.
- The overwritten 8 in egymáshoz was undisclosed; it is now an uncertainty.
- The clear note was silently normalised; it is now given literally as well.
- A sentence on the verse layout was misleading and has been rewritten, and the partial postmark evidence is now reported. The solver also corrected the margin note to "1916, I/11."

Reproduction

From the repository root, `python3 -I ciphers/hcp-1158/work/decode.py` checks the hashes of the four scans, decodes work/transcription.txt through the key, asserts each line against the stated reading and prints the text.